

More than 900 soldiers have lost their lives battling militancy in tribal areas.



LICENSED TO KILL: Pakistani soldiers patrolling Afghanistani border areas

areas that an American agenda is at work despite the Government's repeated assertions that the fight against extremist elements is in the country's own interest.

In this context, the attack on Bhutto is not altogether surprising. Her return to Pakistan after eight years of self-imposed exile is increasingly seen in Pakistan as having been scripted by Western powers, particularly the Americans and the British. Her contacts with the US and the UK Government functionaries prior to the "deal" with General Pervez Musharraf have been widely reported in the media, as have US Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice's statements in her support. The Americans have especially been frustrated by Musharraf's inability to rein in the militants—whose support to the Taliban also threatens NATO's (North Atlantic Treaty Organisation) efforts to quell violence in Afghanistan—and are fearful of the militancy spilling over and destabilising all of Pakistan. Although it still con-

siders Musharraf as its best bet, the General's plummeting popularity after the Chief Justice Iftikhar Muhammad Chaudhry fiasco and his lack of democratic legitimacy make the US uneasy about the future of Pakistan.

American and British diplomats in Pakistan seem to be sold on the idea that the only way of countering such a threat is for the "moderate forces" to come together to oppose extremism. With secular and liberal PPP still the largest "moderate force" in Pakistan, it was only natural for them to push both Musharraf and Bhutto towards each other, regardless of how such an arrangement might work out in the long term.

Bhutto has also vowed to "confront terrorists" and made it a point to stress that she entered into negotiations with a military ruler—against the long-standing principles of her party—because she saw rising extremism as a bigger threat to Pakistan's stability. Musharraf has said

as much in defence of his negotiations with a politician accused of "plundering the national exchequer". A mobile text message doing the rounds, takes jibes at both and presents the scenario as a film called *The Return of Phoolan Devi*, directed by Rice, scripted in London, produced by GHQ, adding, "action choreographed by Al Qaeda".

From all accounts, the Islamist militants now see Bhutto as an extension of Musharraf's regime. Given the PPP's impressive show of force in Karachi, expectations are rife that Bhutto would have a substantial stake in any future government, including the interim pre-election government scheduled to come into power by November 15 when the current assemblies complete their tenure. Prodded

by the Americans, it is also evident that the PPP has managed to patch up with another potent "moderate" force, the Muttaheda Qaumi Movement (MQM), which is closely allied to Musharraf and is a major player in the urban centres of Sindh.

Whatever else may be the difficulty Bhutto faces in any future set-up with Musharraf at the helm of the state, she is also bound to get a bitter first-hand experience of tackling militancy. She has claimed she had "tackled militancy successfully" in her previous two stints as prime minister and pointed out that only a democratic dispensation can hope to control the disaffection that breeds extremism. Most people in Pakistan would be hoping she is correct in her assessment despite the fact that some point out that the Taliban was formed in Afghanistan under her government's admitted tutelage in 1995. But she may find out that rolling back on an extremist mindset, when she herself was perceived as the enemy, may be a more difficult task than she had imagined. ■